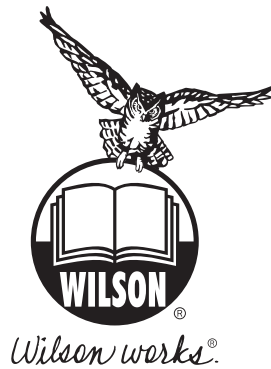


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Take Cover!

When you think of a severe storm, the roll of thunder or a tornado may come to mind. However, researchers maintain that hailstorms are among the most commonly reported storms throughout the world. That explains why about 5,000 are reported each year in the U.S. Hailstorms are five times more frequent than tornadoes.

What is hail and how does it form? Mainly, hailstones form during strong thunderstorms. Winds carry drops of water upward to a level where they turn from liquid to solid ice. These balls of ice, or hail, remain suspended and gain size as they collect layers of ice. When they finally become too large for the wind to support them, the hailstones fall through the air straight down to Earth.

Hailstones the size of baseballs can cause serious harm to people and take a toll on your property, especially vehicles. This can result in long lines at your local car repair shop.

Although humans can't control whether a hailstorm will strike or not, there have been scientific advancements in predicting such storms. People can now be alerted to take cover well before a severe hailstorm hits. That's a good thing for certain because these balls of ice can travel 100 miles per hour straight at you. You may have time to get the family car out of the driveway and to a safe place, but don't delay protecting yourself and your pets as well.

Mitchell Saves A Train Set PART ONE

On his way home, Mitchell went past a large corner lot. He saw a pile of items stacked for trash pick-up. Mitchell parked his bike and went straight over to where the pile of junk lay. He saw some old rusty lamps, a dirty curtain, and several parts of an old telephone. Mitchell was just about to hop back on his bike when he saw an old train set that had been discarded. When he walked over to get a close-up look, he could see that the train set was in fairly good condition. Mitchell had always wanted to obtain a set and now this one was available!

Mitchell picked up the train set and put it in his backpack. In his mind, he was certain he could bring this sad train set back to life. Mitchell made plans to

repair the train set the next day. So, he made a stop at the hobby store before going home. He wanted to obtain some sandpaper and airbrush paint. After he entered the shop, he explained his project to the owner.

There was a display of paint next to the entrance of the store. The shop owner claimed that the paint in the display was the best kind. He suggested Mitchell use a faint gray color. Mitchell also selected a variety of other colors to bring out some of the train's original details. At last, Mitchell could roll along home.

Mitchell Saves a Train Set PART TWO

The next day, Mitchell began to tackle the job of returning the train set to a state of glory once again. The first step was to sand the scratches and remove the old paint. This took a toll on Mitchell's hands as it was a very long process. However, Mitchell's hard work finally paid off. He was ready to give the train set a fresh new look.

Mitchell had to control the airbrush and add the new paint carefully so it would come out evenly. He chose black to cover the straight lines of the grills and each inner chamber. He did research on specific train cars so he could be certain to include particular markings. He expected that his attention to detail would show everybody how special the train set was.

At last, the job was complete. The train set would not be dry for a whole twenty-four hours. Mitchell felt much satisfaction and pride in his well-done task. He couldn't wait to invite his friends over and display the repaired train set.

Ballpark Birthday Celebration

For his birthday, Clayton wanted to go to the local ballpark and watch a baseball game. It was a last minute thought, so Clayton asked his father in a plaintive way if they could go. “No Clay, I’m afraid not,” proclaimed his dad with much dismay. “The tickets are hard to get and rather expensive, especially since it’s playoff time,” he explained straight away.

Clayton was a good sport about it and refrained from complaining. Despite the constraints he would face, Clayton’s dad wanted Clayton to have a great birthday so he attempted to find tickets. Sadly, it was to no avail.

Things were out of his control and Clayton’s father was full of despair. However, he suddenly recalled a certain ballpark maintenance man he used to know.

His name was Aiden. Clayton's dad gave Aiden a call, and it turned out that the old friend was glad to help. Somehow, he was able to get the once unobtainable tickets!

The next morning, Clayton's dad put the tickets on the kitchen table. Clayton was the last one to roll out of bed, but when he finally sat down for breakfast, he saw the special surprise right away. "Baseball tickets!" Clayton exclaimed.

Game day was gray and rainy, but Clayton and his dad did not let this curtail their spectacular time. They even got to visit with some of the baseball players after the game! Clayton was sure it was the best birthday he'd ever had.

A Tiny Snack with Big Benefits

If you like the taste of raisins, you will be pleased to learn that they are good for you too. In fact, they are a great source of energy, vitamins, and minerals.

Raisins are made by drying certain kinds of grapes. This is done either in the sun or in man-made dryers. Grapes contain a lot of sugar. This sugar level becomes more potent in the drying process. Therefore, it is best to control yourself and refrain from overconsumption. Don't despair though! About 1/4 cup of raisins daily will provide plenty of benefits while curtailing the unintended effects of too much sugar.

Raisins contain molecules that help protect the human body from illnesses such as cancer. Daily consumption of raisins may also reduce the risk of

stroke. Snacking on a small box of raisins before exercise may even help sustain you through a long workout.

Raisins are available in most supermarkets. They can also be obtained in some specialty food stores. They are fun to consume plain, straight from the box, or mixed with nuts in a trail mix. Although raisins are good for humans, scientists have proclaimed that they are toxic to dogs. Therefore, it's best to refrain from letting your special pet have a taste.

If you are a raisin fan, maybe you'll fix yourself a special raisin snack to celebrate National Raisin Day next April 30th!

Life in a Tropical Rainforest

Tropical rainforests are tall, dense jungles. As the name suggests, rainforests get lots of rain. In fact, it's fair to say that they sustain as much as 160 inches of rainfall per year!

Rainforests contain beautiful examples of wildlife. Animals there have adapted to this hot and humid place. Furthermore, they have developed special physical traits that help them compete for resources. This explains why some rainforest birds consume particular kinds of foods. For example, a rainforest parrot's claim to fame is its sturdy bill. It aids the bird when cracking nuts and digging out the contents. Another kind of rainforest bird is the toucan. It has a large, long bill. This enables the bird to stretch across branches and grab a pepper or an orange.

Some rainforest animals display traits used to protect themselves. For example, sloths can safely remain undetected by hanging upside down from branches, helping them to blend into the terrain.

Rainforest lizards, snakes, and frogs come in many shades of green. This helps them prevail in a curtain of invisibility. On the other hand, certain kinds of dart frogs have bold colors to call attention to themselves. The colors proclaim danger. This curtails the amount of interaction dart frogs have with other animals. Other animals sense that the bold colors also indicate that dart frogs are quite toxic.

Tropical rainforests are a rich source of plant and animal wildlife, and they are an important part of the world we live in.

The Beehive

Kathleen walked along a small creek. She spent the morning searching for beetles of all kinds. She turned over a rock to see thirteen beetles! She made a quick sketch on a pad of these beetles and then sat under an apple tree to rest. She took a turkey sandwich and a bottle of water out of her backpack.

After she finished her sandwich, Kathleen lay back in the grass. She looked up into the tree. There, on the bottom branch, was a big grey beehive. Even though she didn't see any bees, she quickly moved to rest under another tree. However, she kept her eye on the apple tree.

There was a gentle breeze that felt refreshing on the ninety-degree day. Kathleen fell into a deep sleep

and had a vision that the breeze had become a stiff wind, sweeping the beehive off the branch and onto the grass just beyond the apple tree. She saw fifteen or more bees emerge from the nest, all of them speeding toward her.

At that moment, Kathleen awoke in a panic. She jumped to her feet and wheeled around to look up at the apple tree. She could see that the beehive was just where it had been before she fell asleep, and there were no bees coming her way. She sank back against the tree and proceeded to refine her beetle sketch. It was a terrific day.

Bumblebees and Honeybees PART ONE

Have you ever asked yourself about the buzzing bees speeding around your backyard? Have you thought about what differences you may find between them? With over 20,000 breeds seen throughout the world, it would be difficult to survey them all.

While many bees are alike in some ways, they have considerable differences as well. The bumblebee, for instance, is large, hairy, and has very deep and intense coloring. In contrast, the honeybee is slim, has little hair, and its colors are less lively.

In addition, the honeybee and bumblebee have very different homes. Bumblebees are often found deep in the earth. On the other hand, honeybees usually find a safe space beyond the ground, like in

a tree. Bumblebee nests are generally smaller, with just a few hundred bees living there in winter. Unlike the bumblebee, honeybees keep good company. They stay in the beehive all year with the queen. A honeybee beehive may have thousands of bees!

Bumblebees and Honeybees PART TWO

When it comes to honey production, bumblebees and honeybees are quite different. The honeybee's beehive is where people get the sweet honey we use as food. On the other hand, bumblebees do not produce in excess like the honeybee. They make what they need. With that said, both bumblebees and honeybees are needed for pollination.

Pollination is necessary for plants to reproduce. It happens when pollen grains from the male part of one flower are transferred to the female part of another flower. This process has been made more difficult by the shrinking population of all bees.

The world's crops depend on bees. Honeybees help with the pollination of crops such as melons,

cucumbers, celery, and clover. The bumblebee has been important to the tomato and berry crops in some parts of the world.

The bee population has been passing away at an alarming rate in recent years. Therefore, the humans of planet Earth need to think about things carefully and quickly. We need to find ways to stop the tiny pests that prey on the bee population. We also need to survey how harmful sprays affect insects like the bumblebee and honeybee. It may cost money for scientists to study these things. However, humans need bees and so a solution is key, not only for bees, but for all the inhabitants of Earth!

Nick's Jeep PART ONE

Nick Corey was thrilled when his Uncle Lee handed him the keys to his old jeep. Uncle Lee had recently bought a brand new car, and he didn't need to hold on to the old custom green jeep any longer. At the age of sixteen, Nick was more than cheerful that he had his license and, now, his very own sleek car to drive. His self-esteem was at an all-time high!

The first thing Nick did was to ask his best friend, Billy, to accompany him on a ride to Deer Creek Park. The park was a great place to spend a carefree day.

Before starting out, Nick checked the tires and made sure he had plenty of gas in the jeep. The teens had to drive on the freeway to get to the park. Nick was sure to check the speedometer often so he could

obey the posted speed limits. He was glad there was no need to pay a toll along the way. Nick knew he was better off if his money stayed in the bank!

Nick could not have foreseen how this newly found sense of freedom would feel. It was sheer bliss! He drove with a smile on his face that went cheek to cheek. Before long, the pair of friends made it to the entrance of the state park.

Nick's Jeep PART TWO

Once inside Deer Creek Park, Nick and Billy saw many tall evergreen and maple trees. Turkeys traveled along the edge of the forest while a family of ducks walked out of a creek and toward the street. Nick beeped his horn and quickly pushed down hard on the brakes with a screech. He was able to stop in time to see the ducks safely walk to the other side of the street.

A little beyond the creek, the street turned into a lane of mud and grey rocks. If you were not careful, a vehicle could easily veer off that track! While Billy kept a keen eye out for danger, the jeep crept along. Nick drove slowly and carefully down the lane.

All of a sudden, Billy yelled, “Hey! Be careful! There’s a large rock ahead!” Nick turned the steering wheel just in time but still careened into a deep puddle of mud. This made the wheels on the jeep stop and get stuck in the messy muck. With some effort, Nick was able to step hard on the gas pedal, and soon the jeep was able to free itself from the mud trap.

After a long day in the park, Nick and Billy saw the sun starting to set. The teens were in agreement about starting their trip home before it got too dark. It had been a very special day with a fun ride in Nick’s jeep. They discussed returning to Deer Creek Park again in a week or two!

Birches and Beeches

Survey the forests of North America and you'll see a medley of trees no matter where you live. Two trees that may seem similar at first, birch trees and beech trees, are in fact, quite different indeed.

This pair of trees exists in many a forest terrain, and both are used for construction. However, the beech tree is far more sturdy. In fact, beech trees are so hardy, they are very difficult to chop down. Items that furnish your home are made from sturdy beeches. Outdoors, their strong trunks hold up wide, thick branches stretching up and beyond ninety feet into a wide canopy that offers protection from the rain.

On the other hand, birch trees are straight, thin, and tall, with airy branches. They are far less sturdy

than beech trees, yet birch trunks have often been used as center poles for native people's teepees.

A keen eye will also see major differences between the bark of beeches and birches. Beech tree bark is sleek, thick, and grey. Most people recognize birch trees by their bark, their most interesting trait. The paper-like white bark of a birch tree peels off in long, thin strips. This unusual bark has been used for hundreds of years by native people for covering shelters and homes.

Next time you're in the forest, take a peek and see if you can find a beech or birch close by.

Holiday Dinner

Ashley is hosting holiday dinner for her family. She wants to succeed, so everything must be perfect. Her menu includes turkey, stuffing, rice, and cranberry chutney. However, her dad isn't a fan of turkey, so she'll also serve grilled beef especially for him. For starters, Ashley will put out crackers, cheese, and shrimp cocktail. Dessert will consist of toffee cheesecake.

Ashley goes to the local market to obtain everything she needs. She spends a lot of money, but she is happy to do it for a family gathering like this. On her way home, she swings by the florist to pick up some marigolds and a pair of small pumpkins. They will accompany Ashley's best fall tablecloth and orange candles.

Once she gets home, Ashley gets right to work. She puts a honey glaze on the carrots, and puts the turkey, along with the stuffing, in a big pan. Then, the pan goes into the oven. Then she begins mixing the chutney in a pot on the stove. As that simmers, she tends to the rice. Everything is going well until Ashley spots the time on the clock. She will be greeting her company in just thirteen minutes!

Ashley finishes setting the table and does a quick survey. It looks sleek! Then, she proceeds to set out the crackers, cheese, and shrimp cocktail for everyone to munch on. Ashley slides back into the kitchen to grill the beef and check on the turkey. Indeed, this will be a holiday dinner to remember.

The Crusoe Express

Ed's sister drove him to the Memphis train station to catch a nine o'clock train. Ed and his sister, Lainey, entered the station at seven-thirty with plenty of time to spare. The two siblings walked past the loading dock. There, a cargo train sat with cars loaded with coal and others with scraps of iron.

Ed's plans had him traveling by himself on a passenger train from the city of Memphis, Tennessee to Dallas, Texas. Ed was glad to be boarding a train rather than an airplane, bus, boat, or car. Truth be told, Ed was a serious railroad fan!

Finally, Ed's train came roaring into the station. It was called the Crusoe Express. Ed's ticket was for the coach section since he did not plan to sleep. After

a quick hug, Ed walked toward the train when all of a sudden, the lace on his left shoe got stuck under the tongue of his shoe. This resulted in the shoe coming off his foot. Ed quickly recovered from his stumble and boarded the train without any further issue. When the conductor signaled that the train was departing, Ed knew his thrilling trip was about to begin.

Ed gave his sister a wave, and he could see that she was holding a tissue to wipe her eyes. Lainey knew that she would miss her brother during his long absence from home. The last peek of Ed for a while was that of him on the Crusoe Express as it was speeding effortlessly along the tracks.

Is That a Frog or a Toad? PART ONE

Frogs and toads are cold-blooded animals with skeletons. Both of these animals begin their lives in water. They breathe with gills but later develop lungs to take in air as they grow into adult frogs and toads.

You can argue that frogs and toads belong to the same animal family, but the truth is they are quite different. Let's start with where they live. It's true that frogs and toads can be found on every continent on Earth, except for Antarctica. However, frogs need to live close to water in order to survive. You will find them in and around ponds and lakes. On the other hand, toads spend more time on land so you may even spot one in your garden or in a forest.

Both frogs and toads start out their lives as tadpoles. Over time, they lose their tails and continue on to grow legs until they can roam around on their own. Frogs develop strong, long legs that help them hop. A toad's legs are much shorter, and they are not very strong. That's why it may look like toads creep along to get from one place to another.

It truly may not be a surprise to find out that both frogs and toads like to snack on a broad range of insects. However, did you know that some frogs and toads will even eat small animals like small mice and lizards?

Is That a Frog or a Toad? PART TWO

When you continue to compare a frog to a toad, you will end up seeing more and more differences. The eyes of a frog are unlike the eyes of a toad. A frog's eyes are circular and they extend out from its body. A toad has eyes that truly look like the shape of a chicken egg and they do not stick out at all.

If you are still asking yourself, "Is that a frog or a toad?", here's another clue. Interestingly, toads have special glands behind their eyes that produce a harmful substance. When an enemy approaches a toad, the substance comes out of the gland tissue and can make the other animal become ill.

Frogs have skin that is wet and glossy similar to a raincoat. In contrast, toads have a dry, bumpy coat

of skin. Another major difference is the tongue. Both animals have a long, sticky tongue that explodes out of its throat to catch its prey. You may observe a frog or a toad use its tongue to grab bugs, lizards, and even small mice. However, did you know that frogs have longer tongues?

It's true that frogs have teeth, while toads do not. However, frogs don't use these teeth to bite and munch on their food. The teeth work only to make sure that their prey does not escape the frog's throat. It turns out that both frogs and toads gulp down their prey whole!

Next time you see one of these animals, you can easily decide which it is - frog or toad!

Value Dispute

Sue Phillips was the director of product development for a large corporation. The company was in the midst of a broad expansion. It was truly a trying time. Sue sat at her desk with a detailed report. She had to prepare for Tuesday's committee meeting.

The company was considering the development of a product that did not seem cost-effective. Sue didn't feel that the company should pursue it. She didn't want her department to spend its time developing something that would not succeed in the marketplace. In addition, Sue Phillips felt the value of the product was limited.

She was afraid that the company would merely accrue many expenses that would be harmful in the

long run. As the meeting date approached, she made the decision to argue the issue. She didn't want to see the company lose revenue.

At the meeting, Sue brought the issue up right away so the committee members would have plenty of time to discuss it. She made sure that everyone got a chance to articulate their thoughts, so she bit her tongue while some members began to argue in favor of developing the product. At the conclusion of the meeting, the members put the issue to a vote. By a small margin, they made the decision not to continue with the product development. Sue let out a silent cheer.

Holiday Trip to the City

Joe and Reece walked down a broad avenue dressed in their winter coats and hats. There was no time more festive in the city of New York than the holidays. Joe and Reece were so ecstatic that they felt they were floating on air with every step.

The pair talked and laughed as they took in all the holiday decorations adorning the small shops and large department stores. Outside one such cheerful shop was an outdoor stand. They bought two cups of hot cocoa and a big bag of toasted chestnuts to share.

As Joe and Reece strolled along, they made their way to an inside mall, home to over fifty small shops. They walked down the halls of mistletoe, garlands, and silver bells in amazement. The first venue they entered

was a fancy shop that sold soap, lotion, and perfume. Joe and Reece bought gift packs of bath soap, hand lotion, and sweet-smelling perfume. Adorned with colored tissue paper, these would make perfect gifts for their friends and family.

“To tell you the truth, I think these gift packs are quite expensive,” Joe bemoaned. “Should we be spending that much money?”

“Only the best for our family and friends,” said Reece. “They are going to love these!”

Joe could not argue. When else but the holidays can you splurge like this on the ones you love?

Joe and Reece ended their day in the city with a fondue dinner at a French cafe. It felt good to sit and reflect on the eventful day!

Career Fair Day PART ONE

The August Career Fair Day at Sunshine Middle School was just around the corner. This was cause for joy and celebration, and Audrey and Paula could not wait!

Each August, the sixth-grade students had to develop a poster and presentation about a career they wished to seek when they become adults. Audrey and Paula had actually been loyal friends since they were five. They sought to join together to do everything. This school project would be the same - a joint effort!

The girls gathered all the craft items they needed to develop both of their posters. They worked on Audrey's poster first.

Audrey was sure about her plans for adult life. She had caught the space bug early. There was no way to avoid it. You see, Audrey had always wanted to be an astronaut and launch into space. She was brave and intelligent, both requirements for life as a space traveler.

Once Audrey's poster was drawn and in good shape, the girls started on Paula's poster.

Career Fair Day PART TWO

Paula longed to be an author. She was a huge fan of fiction books. Her love for novels resulted in her wanting to have her own voice, or thoughts, reflected in books. In fact, she wished for her text to be available in every school library someday. Paula was clever and full of imagination, perfect traits for an author.

The two best friends sought more than just positive attention for their posters. They also wanted to come up with presentations that were on point. They fought through their exhaustion and performed their talk in front of each other until they did not feel awkward anymore. In the end, Audrey and Paula were as ready as they could be.

On the day of the career fair, the sixth-grade boys and girls presented their posters and information on their choice jobs in the large school hall. There were posters representing a college professor, a popular fashion model, and an actual cowboy - to name a few. In the end, there was much applause. The Career Day Fair was a big success! Most importantly, the future astronaut and future author were full of pride.

Dinner with Leroy

Shawn walked to the subway station after a long day of work in the fashion district. For a moment, Shawn thought he should stop and get dinner at a local restaurant on his way home. However, he proceeded straight home.

As soon as he entered his kitchen, Shawn began to broil some tuna. He also made coleslaw and rice with oyster sauce.

It wasn't long before his scrawny cat, Leroy, turned up. He could smell something flavorful. Shawn presented his pal Leroy with a plate containing a few small chunks of the moist tuna. As Leroy dug into his dinner, Shawn sat at the kitchen table to do the same.

Leroy finished his food in a hurry and began pawing at Shawn as if to ask for some more. Leroy set his paw softly on Shawn's leg, avoiding hurting him with one of his sharp claws. Well, Shawn couldn't resist the cuteness of dear old Leroy. He gave in and tossed him some more tuna, but, once again, Leroy sought more.

"You're so spoiled, Leroy," said Shawn with a grin. "I thought I had taught you to have some manners."

When he was finally full, Leroy rolled his exhausted body up like a coil on the sofa. He fell asleep noiselessly with some of his cat toys around him.

Shawn was so glad he hadn't gone to a restaurant after all. A homemade dinner and time with his loyal pet cat was actually what he needed after a long day of work.

Why Do We Yawn?

You are probably no stranger to the truly awkward experience of being caught in the middle of a yawn while somebody is talking to you. Don't let it spoil the moment. As annoying as it may be, yawning is a reflex. Therefore, your brain can't control it or prevent it from happening.

What is the purpose of yawning? Several researchers have sought answers to this question. Interestingly, no expert has actually come up with a single, well-accepted theory. However, here is one that is fun to consider.

When we yawn, we open our jaws wide. Then, we draw a big breath of air into our lungs. People report that it usually happens when they are either exhausted or without entertainment. Almost all animals with a backbone yawn. This suggests that the reflex has been

around for a long time, perhaps since before humans developed oral language. These facts have led to the theory that the purpose of yawning is to communicate something. For example, a yawn could signal that one cannot perform certain functions, such as staying alert to protect others. If the person who drives a car yawns again and again, it signals that someone else needs to take the wheel to avoid an accident.

Yawning while someone is talking to you will probably never be in fashion, yet it is sometimes unavoidable. Yawning likely serves more than one purpose, though its actual function remains a question.

At Home in the Forest

Roy's family dwelled in a log cabin in the beautiful northwest region of the United States where forests and rivers supported a diverse wildlife. Massive trees and dense vegetation made a perfect environment for native birds and other animals to thrive.

Roy's family took very few trips to stores because they were too far away. So, at an early age, Roy and his siblings had been taught to live off the land.

All during his life, Roy sought to learn the name of every plant in the area. He learned how to find the safe ones and how to avoid the plants that produce poison. Roy knew the names of every bird that could be heard squawking in the distance.

Roy could carve decoys that he deployed to help him hunt. He could fashion an actual tomahawk with just a few sticks and stones. Roy also knew how to keep his fishing line taut to catch fish. Dinner in the log cabin was often the fish he caught during the day.

Roy was aware that a home in the forest had some drawbacks. In the winter, you fought the harsh cold and the annoying winds. The spring thaw came late, so it took time for the soil to be ready for planting. He did not mind these obstacles because he thought a home in the forest was a gift. Furthermore, Roy took pride in his life-sustaining skills.

Behind the Scenes

The Oyster Club was a popular place to celebrate an anniversary, birthday, or any special day. Shawna was recently employed as Director of Food Preparation at the club restaurant. She enjoyed her job, especially when working at a fancy party.

On this particular day in August, Shawna gathered all of the employees for a meeting about a birthday celebration later that day. She sought to make each of them feel joyful about the event. The kitchen staff all joined the conversation about how to make the event run flawlessly from behind the scenes.

The menu was just one challenge. To start, every guest would get a small portion of freshly caught and battered oysters with Shawna's special sauce. For the main course, there would be a choice of roasted

tenderloin or broiled bluefish. For dessert, a tray with assorted cakes would be passed around.

There needed to be a joint effort in the kitchen in order to get everything set. Shawna kept an eye on everyone and everything. She knew she would be annoyed if she caught anyone walking around aimlessly.

With the food ready to serve and the tables set, Shawna felt that the preparation was actually in good shape an hour before the party was expected to begin. As long as she avoided any major disaster, the party was sure to be a success. As it turned out, all of the club's employees exceeded her expectations and worked until they were exhausted. There were no disappointments. The new Director of Food Preparation was overjoyed!

Hawks and Falcons

Both hawks and falcons are birds of prey and share several traits. Males are smaller than females. They have huge eyes specially adapted to augmenting their hunting skills. They can pinpoint prey from a great distance and keep precisely focused while flying to ensure it is caught. If our eyes were as big as those of hawks and falcons, relative to the size of our skulls, they would be the size of oranges!

Some of the main differences between hawks and falcons relate to their coy hunting habits. The hawk uses only its pointed talons to catch and kill its prey. Falcons, on the other hand, also deploy their stronger, sharper beaks to sever the necks of their prey. You see, falcons have a notch on their beaks that hawks do not have.

Falcons are generally smaller than hawks, but hawks have shorter wings than falcons. One kind of falcon, called the peregrine falcon, has wings that taper to a point. This particular kind of falcon can fly faster than any hawk. Falcons are actually reported to be the fastest animals in the world, with daunting speeds exceeding 200 miles per hour during a dive for prey.

Both hawks and falcons have a similar lifespan. They can both live up to twenty years. Hawks tend to live in regions of North and Central America, but you can find falcons on all continents of the world except Antarctica.

Raccoons

Raccoons are woodland animals native to North America. They live in country forests, but have also adapted to live close to swamps, mountains, and even towns. Over the years, raccoons have been transported to other continents. Some people think raccoons are pests and do their best to get rid of them.

Raccoons are usually active in the evening, but people shouldn't panic if they encounter one in the afternoon. Sometimes raccoons wake up because they're thirsty or hungry, and they will go seek out food and drink while the sun is still up. In some places, you can see them getting a drink from a swimming pool!

If a raccoon is awake during the afternoon and looks sick or is acting odd, then it's important to not

touch it and to call the local experts who handle wild animals. They'll know what to do in this tough position.

Raccoons have a distinct look. In fact, they look almost like a cartoon. How so? Well, for one thing, raccoons who get to adulthood can be quite tubby. They also have skillful front paws, a brownish or black stripe that extends from their heads to their snouts, black rings on their tails, and a mask across their eyes. Because of this mask, raccoons are thought of as little robbers who will get into your trashcans or take your birdseed. It's also not uncommon for raccoons to be seen clowning around. However, most of the time, you'll just see them chowing down on some kind of snack.

A Visit to the Country

Every year, I visit my cousin, Cooper, in the state of Alabama. Cooper lives in the country in a beautiful, old farmhouse that used to belong to our grandparents. It's the coolest farmhouse I have ever seen. It has many bedrooms and bathrooms in it, so our family always has a place to stay when we stop by.

My cousin Cooper loves cooking, so when I got there during my last visit, we cooked dinner together. We used his best cookbook and made a lot of food. We made clam chowder, mushroom pizza, and chocolate marshmallow cups. We both ate a couple of those! It was a fun time.

The next day, we worked in the flower garden, the greenhouse, and in the henhouse. The rooster

wasn't happy about that. Cooper and I even painted the woodshed. After all those chores, Cooper and I went downriver on a raft. It was so empowering to go up against the rough and wild waves. Later that day, we went to a local football game, and it was crowded! It was also a bit cold, so we brought a woolen blanket with us.

In the morning, I had to take off from cousin Cooper's place and travel back home. I had a great vacation and was sad to go, but it was good to sleep in my own bed once again and rest from the farm chores for a while!

Bowling in the Attic

Rowena had a love for bowling, but it was tough to get enough experience. Her parents chose to live in the country, far away from any actual bowling lanes.

Rowena's father said she should try basketball. Rowena frowned and scooted in the house knowing that basketball was not for her. That's when it struck her. Rowena had a plan! Tomorrow, she would make a bowling lane in the attic.

Upon checking out the attic, Rowena found that it would take a lot of time to clear a space for her bowling lane. So many boxes - things she had played with when she was younger. There were sketchbooks, a scooter, old books, and even a couple of mousetraps. Rowena had to choose a new place to store all of these items.

It was rough going, but she finally had the room she needed. She used wood for the sides of the lane to keep the ball going in the right direction. She set up bowling pins that she found at a garage sale. Finally, she had done it! She had made a bowling lane in her attic!

Rowena was so thrilled with herself as she sent her first ball plowing down the lane! Downstairs, her parents, however, were not thrilled. The next day, a basketball hoop was nailed to the garage.

Solar vs. Lunar Eclipse

An eclipse is a profound event that involves the Sun, the Moon, and Earth. A lunar eclipse happens when Earth moves between the Moon and the Sun. Earth casts a shadow large enough to block out all or part of the Moon. A solar eclipse happens when the Moon moves between Earth and the Sun, and the Moon's shadow blocks some or all of the Sun.

A lunar eclipse occurs at night when the Moon is visible, while a solar eclipse occurs during the day. A lunar eclipse can only happen when the Moon and Sun are in line with Earth, as with a full Moon. However, thorough research has shown that this does not happen every time the Moon is full because Earth tilts on its axis and the shadow doesn't line up fully.

While a similar amount of total eclipses can be found for the Sun and the Moon, you are less likely to encounter a total solar eclipse. This is, in part, because the shadow that covers the Moon during a lunar eclipse is quite large and lasts for hours. A solar eclipse only lasts a few minutes due to the smaller shadow of the Moon.

It is safe to walk outside or look through the window during a lunar eclipse, however, you may be better off studying a solar eclipse in a textbook. Without proper protection, a solar eclipse can be very tough on your eyes, even doing permanent harm to them.

Neither eclipse has a specific timetable, but there are usually a couple of each kind every year. You may need to do some research in your classroom to find out about when you can see one next!

Lost

Speeding through the Vancouver forest on a December afternoon, the snowmobile cut fresh, smooth tracks. The open terrain was a place for the girls to let loose. It was an especially beautiful day, so Sandy and her cousin, Paula, took the snowmobiles out for fun.

The broad trail stretched out in a southwesterly direction for miles then returned to the winter camp. Along the way, it looped around a shallow pond and up over a steep hill. After zooming down the hill, Paula came to a stop. She suggested they go off the trail to explore. Sandy felt it was probably a foolish thing to do, but she followed her cousin anyway.

Paula gave a gleeful whoop as she steered her snowmobile off the path. They wound through the backwoods until they encountered a level area. While

resting there, they heard the sound of pounding hooves, then saw a couple of moose! They were so close they could almost touch them.

As the afternoon progressed, the sky filled with gray clouds. The girls had to find the trail soon or risk getting lost! At first, their search seemed hopeless. The Sun began to fade, and the shadows became longer. The girls were overcome by apprehension. They fought the urge to panic as a spooky feeling crept into their minds. They seemed to be going in endless circles.

Finally, Paula heard the faint sound of another snowmobile. The cousins followed the sound, which became louder, and sure enough, they found the trail! With darkness looming, they sped back to camp in record time.

Monsoon

In some parts of the world, such as India, almost all of the rainfall arrives with the summer monsoon, a predictable change in the prevailing, or strongest, wind. This usually occurs between June and September, when humid air from the southwest Indian Ocean blows over the hot land, bringing grey rain clouds into the region. When the prevailing wind shifts again in the fall, the northeast winds of the winter monsoon bring extremely hot, dry conditions.

Since over half of India's population works in farming, the monsoon cycle is very important to the country's economy. While the summer and its counterpart winter monsoons are predictable events, the amount of rainfall varies from one year to the next.

Usually, the summer monsoon brings enough rain to fill wells and aquifers that store water underground for use during the rest of the year. But a limited summer monsoon is tough on farmers because too little rainfall prevents crops from growing, and dairy farmers get caught without enough water to keep cows well-fed.

On the other hand, an extremely powerful summer monsoon can produce too much pounding rain and result in destructive mudslides, overflowing rivers, and floods. In India, the monsoons are among the most important elements that affect the well-being of the entire country's population.

A Beautiful Time of Year

By any measure, fall is a beautiful season in the northeast region of the U.S. It is often considered the best time of year by the people who live there - a true treasure. The steamy summer weather gives way to pleasant and cool sweater weather once again.

Colorful leaves start to appear on the trees in mid-September. This results in the usual green landscape turning red, yellow, orange, peach, cranberry, and golden brown. Wear your sneakers and hike up a mountain peak. The display will take your breath away. Don't wait too long, though. By mid-October, some of the leaves will begin to drift to the ground and break down.

Seasoned travelers find many reasons to approve a visit to this region of the country during September and October. In fact, serious leaf peepers repeat the trip yearly. In addition to the beautiful landscape, people find pleasure in visiting country fairs. They may also be eager to pick apples and feast on apple donuts and other treats at local orchards. Others just like to breathe in the cool, crisp air.

If you are lucky enough to find yourself in the northeast in the fall, one thing is for sure. You won't be disappointed by the beautiful season.

Fast, Fearless Hunters PART ONE

Eagles are among the most powerful of all birds of prey. Two of the most prominent examples are the Golden Eagle and the American Eagle, also called the Bald Eagle.

Both birds have dark brown chests, beaks that curve, and broad wings that measure about six feet across when stretched out. However, it is quite simple to tell these two kinds of eagles apart. The Golden Eagle has golden colored feathers on the back of its head and neck. On the other hand, the American Eagle has a distinctive white head. The American Eagle is also the only eagle that does not have feathers on its legs.

Eagles mate and remain a couple for life. Male and female eagles pair up and construct a huge nest

together. They break dead branches off trees to build the nest. Golden Eagle nests, while large, are not as deep or quite as heavy as an American Eagle's nest, which can weigh up to four thousand pounds! Both kinds of eagles return to the same nest yearly and add sticks to increase its size and improve its strength.

The Golden Eagle is widely spread across several continents. In contrast, the American Eagle is found only in North America. Its likeness appears on the U.S. dollar bill as well as on the national seal. Considered a national treasure, the Bald Eagle has maintained the ability to earn the respect of many generations of Americans today and will inspire those of tomorrow.

Fast, Fearless Hunters PART TWO

Eagles are excellent, fearless hunters. Golden Eagles usually inhabit inland areas. They hunt mainly for small mammals that range in size from rabbits to foxes. American Eagles, on the other hand, usually live near water. They hunt mainly for fish and sometimes seals.

The Golden Eagle will fly at a steady speed looking for food, then make a sudden dive at 150 to 200 miles per hour. In contrast, the American Eagle grabs its prey from a low, level flight. It can reach a speed of about 75 miles per hour.

For the first several weeks of a young Golden Eagle's life, the female tends the nest. A male Golden Eagle hunts and brings food back. The female then tears the food into small bits to drop directly into the young eagle's

mouth. On the other hand, both the male and the female American Eagle leave the nest in search of food for the young to feast on.

When it comes to eating, Golden and American Eagles don't always earn their meal. Instead of working to catch and kill a treasure of live prey, they are content to eat dead animals. American Eagles also steal prey from other birds.

The threats from the environment will probably always be present. However, conservation efforts continue to improve the eagles' rate of survival and appear to have successfully protected the eagles of tomorrow.

Gorillas

Native to Africa, gorillas are the world's grandest primates. The different kinds of gorillas fall neatly into two overall groups - the Eastern and the Western gorilla. These two groups can then be further split into two more sets. The widespread lowland gorilla lives in the dense, level forests of central and western Africa. The mountain gorilla inhabits the realm of the great mountains of central Africa.

Lowland and mountain gorillas share many traits. Yet, there are also differences to note. Both groups of adult gorillas measure roughly four to six feet tall. However, the mountain gorilla is heavysset next to the lowland gorilla. Both eat plenty of leaves and shoots, though the lowland gorilla eats more fruit than the

mountain gorilla. For a special treat, the Eastern lowland gorilla occasionally feeds on insects.

Gorillas live in groups called troops. As many as fifty members can be led by a dominant male with a streak of grey hair on his back. Mornings and evenings are mealtimes for these animals. The middle of the day is usually spent playing, grooming, or seeking the pleasure of a nap instead. In the evening, gorillas sleep on layers of leaves and twigs.

Lowland and mountain gorillas are endangered. The main threats are illegal hunting for meat, the spread of illness by humans, and habitat loss. Will conservation efforts prove successful enough to increase the population of these great apes?

The Class Retreat PART ONE

Heath did not mean to dread the following day, but he did, nonetheless. As he sat and thought about tomorrow, he tried hard to concoct a stealth plan to break out of The Pheasant School before the bus pulled up to take the students on their class retreat.

Headmistress Channing was in charge of the whole thing. She had proudly instructed the students about their time away, what to pack, and, most importantly, all the rules to follow. Heath was certain this class retreat would prove to be a bust. He'd rather just skip it. However, his mother would not hear of such a thing. The retreat was a tradition. She expected Heath to go on the trip, enjoy himself, and spend time with his fellow classmates.

This year, The Pheasant School class retreat would be held at nearby Eagle Farm. The students would get to experience life on a farm while bonding with each other as a team for a few days. Heath felt he could not breathe, and he wanted to scream!

The Class Retreat PART TWO

Heath got to school the next day on time despite his lingering around the breakfast table too long. When it was time for the tenth-grade class to make their way to the bus, headstrong Heath persisted with his disapproval.

Heath took a seat in the front of the bus and displayed his displeasure with a frown. It wasn't long before the bus pulled up to Eagle Farm. Heath really had to admit, the homestead was a beautiful site. The old farmhouse and recently refurbished barn were painted a candy apple red. The buildings contrasted with the vast green fields and meadows. Heath's mood started to improve just a wee bit.

After a tour of the farmland, the students sat down to dinner with Farmer Joan and her family. Much to Heath's surprise, the meal was fantastic! The students went to bed early to prepare for a hectic day tomorrow.

The students spent the next few days harvesting peas that had been planted in early spring. They planted soybeans that would be ready for harvesting in the fall and took care of the farm animals. In between all the hard work, Heath and his classmates sang songs, played games, and laughed.

By the end of the retreat, Heath was filled with pleasure, not dread. Instead, he was regretful about his original attitude. He confessed that he had been wrong. The whole endeavor turned out to be a treat!

Ready Reuben, the Firehouse Cat

Reuben was a cat who called the Newport Firehouse his home for many years. One cold December evening a long time ago, someone called to say that a kitten was stuck in a sewer drain in the center of town. When the station's firemen and firewomen were finally able to rescue the shivering little guy, they instantly fell in love with him. However, right away they attempted to find the real owner. They would feel too guilty keeping him if they knew that someone was looking for the sweet and innocent kitten. After a few weeks, no one came forward to claim the gray and white kitten. So, the fire station formally adopted him and gave him the name Reuben.

Reuben began life anew, and soon he grew to be a fearless and loyal agent of the firehouse. In fact, he was the first one to jump into the fire truck when the alarms went off. This quickly earned him the nickname Ready Reuben. His new family even got Reuben a small firecat suit and built him a small seat so he could see out of the firetruck window. Reuben had no clue that he was a station pet. He really thought he was part of the station crew!

It turns out that Reuben was well-suited for life as a public employee. He enjoyed all the attention and often got the chance to bring some peace to people in times of crisis. Visitors would stop by the fire station all the time just to say hello to the firehouse cat!

Fruit or Vegetable?

There is a bit of a feud between scientists and cooks. They often argue about the difference between a fruit and a vegetable.

A scientist will tell you that fruit is any part of a plant that contains seed, whereas a vegetable is all the other plant parts, such as the leaves, roots, and stems. Using this definition as a guide, a tomato, for example, is a fruit. The same is true for the American cucumber. However, a seedless European cucumber is a vegetable.

Cooks, on the other hand, consider fruit to be sweeter and more suitable as a dessert. They approve of vegetables for other parts of a meal. So, when they buy vegetables, a cook may choose a tomato, and

either an American or a European cucumber. Although cooks consider few vegetables to be fruit, they do use several fruits, such as tomatoes and cucumbers, as vegetables.

Fruits and vegetables are both parts of plants. They are rich in vitamins, minerals, and fiber. Eating lots of these foods benefits your health. However, fruit juice and vegetable juice do not have the fiber value of whole fruits and vegetables. Vegetables also contain less sugar and fewer calories than fruits.

There's no need to feel guilty about picking sides with scientists instead of cooks or vice versa. Just begin anew and make a point to eat both of these healthy foods every day.

The Anglerfish

Stewing in the depths of the world's ocean lives an interesting critter not suited for the light of day - the anglerfish.

Don't feel guilty if you've never seen or heard of this fish. One of the least attractive fish you can find, the anglerfish does not cruise around just anywhere. These fish live their entire lives in the deepest darkest parts of the ocean.

Fully grown, an anglerfish can range from 8 to 40 inches in length and weigh as much as 110 pounds. Anglerfish can catch and eat other fish twice their own size. Hunting prey in pitch-black water is a challenge. So, the female anglerfish has a built-in method for catching her dinner. A glowing jewel-like organ on top of her head guides unsuspecting prey into chewing range.

The male anglerfish does not sport this same “jewelry.” Adapting to suit its dark environment, a male will attach itself to a nearby female. Over time, the male anglerfish will lose most of his own organs. At the end of this process, it’s as if he regrew to be part of the female. If more than one male anglerfish ends up seeking the same female, it’s okay. You see, a female anglerfish can carry around six or more males on her body.

You won’t get the chance to see one of these strange fish while enjoying a day at the beach in your swimsuit. However, an online search may produce a few photographs to help you see what this unusual and unattractive fish actually looks like.

On the Rise

Ashley Newton is a newscaster in great demand. She strives to deliver the news precisely and frankly every day. Ashley has worked at a local news station for the past ten years. However, she is now in possession of an offer to deliver the news for a national news channel. This is what she has always wanted!

Ashley began her career as an investigative reporter. She would shrewdly outmaneuver even the best detectives to get to the bottom of a case. This is how the talented reporter got the nickname, The Sleuth in Pursuit.

Ashley calls her brother, Andrew, to tell him the good news. Andrew is the kind of guy anyone would love to have as a sibling. He is instantly happy for his

older sister. He knows how hard she has worked to fulfill her dreams. Andrew says to Ashley, “We must celebrate once I return from my European trip. I want to buy you a special dinner and toast your success.”

Over the next few days, the excitement builds among the newsroom crew as word gets out about Ashley’s recruitment. One handshake after another confirms that Ashley Newton will be missed. However, before the rumors start brewing, she tells the rest of the staff that she has not packed even one suitcase yet. She informs everyone that she will not move to New York right away. In fact, they will be stuck with her for another month or two! Then, she will at last head to the big city for her next news challenge.

Tragedy at Sea

In April 1912, roughly 2,224 passengers and crew boarded the newly built cruise ship for a transatlantic crossing from Europe to New York. For the wealthy passengers carrying bags packed with fancy clothes and jewelry, the crossing on the Titanic was meant to be a pleasure cruise. Others boarded the ship to start life anew in the U.S.

As the ship's horns blew in farewell and the crew cast off, no one knew of the tragedy that lay ahead. When the ship approached Newfoundland, the captain was aware that icebergs were common in the region and commanded the crew to keep a lookout. However, the ship had few navigational aids to detect their exact location and guide the ship to a safe course.

The captain attempted to maneuver the ship around an iceberg, but was unsuccessful in his pursuit. The huge ship could not turn fast enough. Moments after the ship struck the iceberg, holes from the impact below the ship's waterline allowed water to overwhelm the vessel. There were too few lifeboats for passengers and crew, and not enough training for the crew to launch them properly. As the ship sank, the frigid water around it was strewn with evidence of the destruction.

Fewer than a third of the passengers and crew made it out alive. Prompted by the massive loss of life, a number of new international safety regulations were put in place following the disaster.